

Figure 2. Remains of ancient Varanasi

When Xuanzang visited Sarnath in c. 635 CE, it had hundreds, possibly thousands, of monks. The ‘country’ of Varanasi, Xuanzang wrote, has a circumference of about 1000 km. ‘The families are very rich, and in the dwellings are objects of rare value. The disposition of the people is soft and humane, and they are earnestly given to study . . . a few revere the law of the Buddha. The climate is soft, the crops abundant, the [fruit] trees flourishing, and the underwood thick in every place.’ He estimated thirty Buddhist monasteries and 3000 monks, and a ‘hundred or so’ temples with 10,000 devotees of Shiva. Some of them, he wrote, ‘cut off their hair, others tie their hair in a knot, and go naked, without clothes; they cover their bodies with ashes, and by the practice of all sorts of austerities they seek to escape from [the cycle of] birth and death’. The ‘densely populated’ capital of this country was by the Ganga and had about twenty temples, ‘the towers and halls of which are of sculpted stone and carved wood. The foliage of trees combines to shade (the sites), whilst pure streams of water encircle